

Dossier C – “Opium of the People” as Media Design Brief

Filename: C_Marx_Opium_Media_CommitteeMinutes.pdf

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(Found among miscellaneous papers, Box 4857-E)

Document type: COMMITTEE MINUTES (UNSIGNED)

Date: ca. 1844–1848 (internal references)

Location: Western Europe (exact city unknown)

Subject: APPLICATION OF “OPIUM OF THE PEOPLE” THESIS TO MASS MEDIA

1. Background (archivist’s note)

This document was found tucked between pamphlets from mid-19th century socialist and liberal associations. It appears to be a set of minutes from a small committee—possibly pseudonymous—discussing the political implications of Karl Marx’s famous remark that religion is “the opium of the people.”

In context, Marx writes that religion is both “*the sigh of the oppressed creature*” and “*the opium of the people*”—a metaphor indicating that religion both soothes suffering and, by doing so, helps maintain existing social conditions. The unknown author(s) here take this as a **design challenge**.

2. Excerpted minutes

“Comrade M. has clarified that religion functions as a narcotic: it dulls the pain of exploitation while keeping the sufferer in place. It is not merely a lie, but a consolation that becomes an instrument of rule.wikipedia+2

We must anticipate that as literacy spreads, the churches’ monopoly over this function will weaken. The same industrial forces that create the proletariat will also create **new opiums**: cheap print, novels, serialized tales, and in time devices we cannot yet name.

Question before the committee: how shall the ruling circles seek to capture these new instruments before the workers do?”

One participant (initialed “E.”) suggests:

“If the people are to become readers, let us ensure that what they read keeps them busy, hopeful, and divided. Instead of sermons of heaven, there will be **stories of upward mobility** and gossip about the lives of the rich.

The important thing is not the content’s truth, but its capacity to absorb attention and redirect anger from structures to individuals.”

Another voice (initial "S.") adds:

"The churches promise relief in the next life. Our new opium must promise relief **in this life soon**, but always just out of reach. Promotion, lottery, celebrity.

If we can flood the printed world with such tales, the workers will dream of joining the masters, not overthrowing them."

3. The nine-eye seal

At the end of the document, a wax impression appears: nine eyes in a circle around a blank centre—the same motif seen on the Mesopotamian tablets and Silk Road watchtower. Under it, a motto in Latin:

"Scriptum Secundum: qui narrant regunt."

("Second Writing: those who narrate, rule.")

The minutes then break off:

"In future, the opium may need no altar and no pulpit. It will be carried by the very machines that deliver wages, food, and news.

Once people live inside a net of such stories, they will think themselves awake even as they dream..."

[REMAINDER OF PAGE TORN AWAY]

The document does not identify the group using the nine-eye seal; whether it is a private circle of intellectuals, a state-linked organisation, or something more diffuse remains unspecified. The reader is invited to infer its role in steering each new "opium" medium as it appears.